THE HOLLOW HEIR

The Quest Guide

Getting players to bite, and every quest in depth

Hooks, nudges and tricks for steering a table that never does what you expect.

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Contents

The Quest Guide 3

How quests work in the app 3

Twelve ways to make them bite 3

When they ignore a quest 4

When they break a quest 4

The quest calendar 4

Every quest in depth 6

The Hollow Heir 6

Keep an Eye Out 7

Stolen Ingredients 7

Dueling Club Champion 8

Card Collector 9

Wake the Sleepers 10

Where is Bramble? 11

The Other Half 11

The secret quests 12

The Old Cup 12

The Turning Lock 13

PART 7

The Quest Guide

How to get a table to bite, and every quest in depth.

A quest is just a reason to go somewhere and do something. Your players are curious and they will chase anything that looks interesting, but they will also chase things you never planned and ignore the quest you carefully set up. This guide is about steering without pushing: making the quest look more interesting than whatever else they were going to do.

How quests work in the app

- Each quest is **on offer** for a few blocks, from the person who gives it. During that window, the person has a scroll above their head on the TV.
- Give a quest from the Quests tab (tick who it is for) or straight from a conversation. It appears on their phones with its objectives.
- If nobody picks it up before the window ends, the quest giver **sends it by owl** at the start of the next block. Nothing important is ever lost.
- Tick objectives as they happen. Complete pays the rewards and plays the quest scroll on the TV and every hero's phone.
- Secret quests stay hidden until you reveal them, because they are found by curiosity, not handed out.

Twelve ways to make them bite

Technique	How	Example
Make it personal	Tie the quest to a player's family, secret or backstory.	Bramble is the Thornbury's hippogriff. The other half of the map belongs with the Fenwick. Never say "a quest": say "your hippogriff".
Put a face on it	The person asking must care, visibly.	Longbottom's hands shake holding the Mandrake leaf. The prefect pretends she is not frightened. Play the feeling, not the task.
Show, don't tell	Let them see the problem before anyone explains it.	They walk past the raided cupboard before Grimsby storms out. They find the empty frames before anyone mentions portraits.
A ticking clock	Say when the chance ends.	"Scamander says the hippogriff won't stay at the forest edge past tomorrow." The app marks Last chance on the final block.
Put the reward on the table	Say what they get, early and concretely.	"Grimsby gives anyone who finds the jars ten Galleons and two Pepperup Potions." Players love a price tag.
A rival wants it too	Competition makes anything valuable.	Cassius wants the Dueling Club title. Cassius has the other half of the map. Peeves is going to throw the jars at someone.
Curiosity over obligation	A locked thing, a riddle, a noise. Nobody can resist.	The ticking chest in the Room of Requirement. The riddle on the old cup. A rune tablet nobody can read.
Let them overhear it	Information they were not supposed to get is always more exciting.	Extendable Ears outside Grimsby's office. Pip gossiping with another elf. Two portraits arguing.
Small yes, then big yes	Ask for something tiny first.	"Could you just carry this note to the Hospital Wing?" Now they are in the Hospital Wing, and Longbottom is there.
Give each player a thread	When the party splits, each group should have something to chase.	Thornbury to the forest, Fenwick to the courtyard, the rest to the library. Cut between them on cliffhangers.

Technique	How	Example
Reward the weird solution	If their plan is clever and not on the list, let it work.	Bribing Peeves with a Dungbomb to fetch the jars. A Penrose wearing Filch's face. Let it work, and give house points.
Let ignored quests change the world	Do not force. Show what happened because they didn't.	Nobody found the jars: Peeves throws them in the Great Hall, and Grimsby blames the first-years. Nobody went to Bramble: she is gone deeper, and harder to find.

When they ignore a quest

Climb this ladder one rung at a time. Most quests are picked up by rung two.

Rung	What you do
1. Ask again, differently	The quest giver finds them at the next meal with a new angle: more personal, more urgent, or a better reward.
2. The owl	The app sends the quest by owl when the window closes. The letter is written in the giver's voice. It lands at breakfast in front of everyone.
3. The world moves	Something happens because they waited: another victim, a rival takes the prize, a clue is lost.
4. Let it go	Some quests are just not for this table. Drop it, and if it mattered, find the important part another way (see the rule of three in Part 6).

When they break a quest

They will solve things the wrong way, skip steps, kill the thing you needed alive, or lose the item. Never let a quest end in "you can't do that". Fail forward: the quest continues, but differently.

They skip a step	Tick it anyway. If the step mattered, its information arrives another way.
They lose a quest item	Someone finds it and returns it, for a price: Peeves wants a favour, Filch wants an apology, a portrait wants a secret.
They hurt the quest giver's feelings	The giver still needs the job done. They send the reward through someone else, coldly, and the relationship has changed. That is a story too.
They finish it in five minutes	Good. Reward them, and add one complication from the quest's list below to the next quest instead.

The quest calendar

Quest	Giver	On offer	Then by owl
Keep an Eye Out	Prefect Sinclair	Day 1 Lunch to Day 2 Free time	Yes
Stolen Ingredients	Grimsby	Day 1 Free time to Day 3 Free time	Yes
Card Collector	Wren Ashby	Day 2 Lunch to Day 5 Free time	Yes
Dueling Club Champion	Flitwick	Day 2 Free time to Day 4 Lunch	Yes
The Hollow Heir (main)	Everyone	After the first victim: Day 2 Curfew to Day 3 Lunch	Yes, from the Headmaster
Wake the Sleepers	Longbottom	Day 3 Lunch to Day 5 Lunch	Yes
Where is Bramble?	Scamander	Day 3 Afternoon to Day 4 Free time	Yes
The Other Half	Cassius	Day 4 Lunch to Day 6 Lunch	Yes, to the Fenwick
The Old Cup (secret)	—	Any detention	No

Quest	Giver	On offer	Then by owl
The Turning Lock (secret)	—	Finding the Room of Requirement; Day 5 Free time to Day 6 Free time	Yes, from an unknown hand
The Painter's Bargain (secret)	The painting	Day 5 Curfew to Day 6 Curfew	Yes, to one student
The Trials Beneath (secret)	—	Reaching the serpent door: Day 7 Lunch to Curfew	No

PART 7

Every quest in depth

Pitches, plays, shortcuts and spanners.

The Hollow Heir

The main quest. Winning it wins the campaign.

Given by	Everyone, after the first victim. The Headmaster's owl if they somehow avoid it.
Objectives	Find out what is draining the students. Learn the painted man's name. Find the way into the Undercroft. Stop the ritual before the seventh night ends.
Reward	150 XP and 50 house points each.

Three ways to pitch it

- The Sinclair's sister is grey in a hospital bed. Nobody needs to ask.
- The Headmaster, privately: "I will not insult you by pretending it was an accident. If you know something, tell me. If you find something, tell me first."
- The portraits, all over the castle, whispering the players' names as they pass. Something has noticed them.

How it usually plays

Through Day 4 it is a slow burn: clues, suspects, wrong guesses. The first two objectives can tick by Day 4 if they are sharp. The rest belongs to Days 5 to 7.

Clever solutions to allow

- Asking every portrait in the castle, one by one (the Blackwood can do this for real).
- Following the paint smears on empty frames to work out where Vale has been.
- Watching Ashgrove's classroom through the spy hole behind the Grand Staircase portraits.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- A third student is drained earlier than planned, near wherever the party is not.
- A teacher forbids first-years from wandering after a new rule: corridors closed after Free time.
- Someone they trust is the Painted Double for a scene.

If they ignore it	It cannot be ignored. If they are not chasing it, the victims come to them: a drained student in their own common room.
The payoff	Every clue they find goes on the suspect board on the TV. By the end of Day 4 the board should be full of arrows. That wall is the reward.

Keep an Eye Out

The prefect's worry. Makes her drained on Day 2 hurt.

Given by	Prefect Sinclair, Day 1 Lunch, to the Sinclair and anyone with them.
Objectives	Meet her after dinner. Follow her patrol. Find what she is afraid of.
Reward	30 XP and 10 house points.

Three ways to pitch it

- To the Sinclair, as family: "Meet me after dinner. Don't tell Mum. Don't tell anyone."
- To the group, as a dare: "You lot look like you can keep a secret. Want to see something creepy?"
- By accident: they see her standing alone by an empty frame, wand lit, looking frightened. She notices them noticing.

How it usually plays

They meet her at the Grand Staircase on Day 1 Curfew (or Day 2), she shows them the corridor of empty frames and the cold dead end near the dungeons. The third step (what she was afraid of) completes when they first see or feel the covered painting.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bringing her a gift (a Chocolate Frog) to make her feel better. +5 points.
- The Okafor touching the wall at the dead end.
- The Quill telling her about the eye on the train: she goes white and says "Me too. In my dreams."

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Filch nearly catches them on the patrol (spin Out after curfew; she covers for them).
- The Cornish Pixies on the Grand Staircase interrupt the meeting.

If they ignore it	She sends the owl on Day 2. If they still do not go, she is drained that night anyway, and the Sinclair finds the owl unopened in their bag. Ouch.
The payoff	On Day 2 Curfew, when she is grey on the floor, the players who walked with her should feel it. That is what this quest is for.

Stolen Ingredients

A comedy with a secret: it plants Grimsby as a suspect and gives the first hint he is decent.

Given by	Grimsby, Day 1 Free time.
Objectives	Search the Dungeons for clues. Catch the thief. Return the jars.
Reward	30 XP, 10 Galleons and two Pepperup Potions each. Grimsby adds 5 points each, quietly.

Three ways to pitch it

- Grimsby, furious and accusing: “If it was a first-year…” They want to prove it wasn’t them.
- A student whispers that Grimsby will give detention to all first-years if nobody confesses.
- They find a jar of lacewing flies on the Grand Staircase first, and Grimsby offers a reward for the rest.

How it usually plays

They find sticky, see-through fingerprints in the cupboard, follow a trail of lacewing wings to the Grand Staircase, and find Peeves juggling the jars on a high landing. Getting them back is the fun part.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bribing Peeves (he loves Dungbombs, and being called frightening).
- Wingardium Leviosa on the jars, or Accio once they have seen them.
- Getting Filch to chase Peeves away (Filch is thrilled to have a reason).
- The Penrose wearing Filch’s face.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Peeves throws a jar: lacewing flies everywhere, and everyone in the corridor sneezes for a block.
- One jar is missing: Peeves gave it to a portrait for safekeeping.
- Grimsby accuses a player of stealing them before they can return them.

If they ignore it	Peeves throws the jars across the Great Hall at Lunch on Day 3. Grimsby blames the first-years: −5 points to every house that has a first-year at the table.
The payoff	Grimsby’s “Five points. Each. Don’t tell anyone.” is the first crack in his armour. When he is found over a victim on Day 5, the players who did this quest will hesitate. Good.

Dueling Club Champion

Pure fun, and the best training for the reaction duel in the finale.

Given by	Flitwick, Day 2 Free time.
Objectives	Beat a rival. Beat two more. Win the final against Cassius.
Reward	40 XP and 15 house points each.

Three ways to pitch it

- Flitwick, bouncing on his books: “A first-year champion! Think of the glory!”
- Cassius, sneering: “First-years in the Dueling Club. That’ll be quick.”
- The whole castle is talking about it. The winner gets their name on a plaque in the Trophy Room.

How it usually plays

The Dueling Club runs every Free time in the Great Hall from Day 2. Place a Dueling Club rival and fight. Turn on the reaction duel on the rival's token so it feels like a real duel. The final is Cassius with rival stats.

Clever solutions to allow

- Fighting as a tag team (Flitwick allows it: "Two against one, how exciting!").
- Psyching the opponent out first: a good CHA roll gives advantage on the first spell.
- Studying the opponents during other duels (WIS: learn their favourite spell).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Cassius cheats: a hidden Jinx on the floor (Quill or Okafor can spot it).
- The crowd chants for the opponent. Disadvantage on the first roll unless someone wins them over.

If they ignore it	Nothing bad happens; they just miss out. Cassius wins and is insufferable about it until Day 7.
The payoff	House points, glory, and players who know exactly how the reaction duel works when the boss uses it for real.

Card Collector

A side trade that pays out a key clue.

Given by	Wren Ashby, from Day 2 Lunch.
Objectives	Find a rare Chocolate Frog card. Trade it to her.
Reward	25 XP and Felix Felicis. And her secret: the painting "came with the new portraits. Ashgrove signed for it himself."

Three ways to pitch it

- She offers a secret about the painting. Mystery players cannot resist that.
- She offers Felix Felicis. Gamers cannot resist that.
- She trades common cards for sweets, so they meet her through the Chocolate Frogs they open.

How it usually plays

The rare card comes from a lucky Chocolate Frog, an Ancient chest, or completing The Other Half. Bringing it to the Library ends the quest.

Clever solutions to allow

- Trading her something else rare (a hippogriff feather, a Gringotts goblin's signature).
- A convincing fake card (INT 14; she checks the back, so it needs to be very good).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Cassius wants the same card.
- She will only trade if they tell her a secret first.

If they ignore it	She sends an owl. If they never trade, they never hear her secret, and the Ashgrove clue must come another way.
The payoff	The secret is the first time anyone ties Ashgrove directly to the portraits. Deliver it slowly.

Wake the Sleepers

The emotional heart of the first half. Brings the prefect back with one vital line.

Given by	Longbottom, Day 3 Lunch, after the second victim.
Objectives	Gather 3 Mandrake leaves. Brew the Restorative Draught. Bring it to the Hospital Wing.
Reward	60 XP, 20 house points and a Wiggenweld Potion each.

Three ways to pitch it

- Longbottom, quietly, holding a leaf: “There’s a draught. It might bring them back.”
- The Sinclair, at their sister’s bedside, being told that there is a chance.
- The matron: “If Professor Longbottom’s draught works, perhaps. Until then, keep your voices down.”

How it usually plays

One leaf comes from each Herbology pass (Day 2). More from chests, from the Greenhouses with a sneaky search, or from Longbottom if asked well. Brewing: an INT check or spin Potion brewing. Grimsby can help (he is brewing the same thing, in secret, and it brings him into the story).

Clever solutions to allow

- Asking Grimsby to help brew. He refuses, then helps. It clears him early, if you want that.
- Stealing a leaf from the Greenhouses at night (DEX 12; the Mandrakes scream if they fail).
- Using the Hale’s Healer’s Hands to judge exactly when the draught is ready (advantage on the brewing roll).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The cauldron explodes (spin Potion brewing), and they need one more leaf.
- Peeves steals the finished draught on the way to the Hospital Wing.
- It only wakes one student. Who do they choose?

If they ignore it	Longbottom brews it alone and it takes until Day 6. The prefect wakes too late to help much.
The payoff	The prefect wakes, grey slowly washing out of her face, and whispers: “The man in the painting… he was wearing Ashgrove’s face.” That line changes the game. Give it full weight.

Where is Bramble?

The Thornbury's quest. A trip into the Forest with a heart.

Given by	Scamander, after Care of Magical Creatures on Day 3. For the Thornbury.
Objectives	Find Bramble's tracks in the Forest. Calm her without hurting her. Bring her out safely.
Reward	50 XP, 15 Galleons and Creature treats each. Bramble can return in the finale.

Three ways to pitch it

- To the Thornbury: "I believe she might be yours."
- A grey feather on the fence by the hut, a torn tag tangled in it. The Thornbury recognises the crest.
- At night, from the common room window: a hippogriff's cry from the Forest. Only the Thornbury knows that call.

How it usually plays

Into the Forest (out of bounds), spin the Forest wheel each step deeper. The centaur gives a warning. The Thornback Boar is around on Day 3. Bramble is deep in, frightened, and will lash out at anyone but the Thornbury. Creature treats and Beast Bond make it gentle.

Clever solutions to allow

- Bowing to Bramble (how you greet a hippogriff). Advantage on calming her.
- Asking the centaur the right way (respectfully, about the stars) for directions.
- The Thornbury going alone. Brave, and Bramble trusts them more.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The boar finds them first.
- Bramble is injured: a Healer's Hands or a potion must come first.
- Filch is at the Forest edge when they come out with a hippogriff. That is a lot of points.

If they ignore it	She goes deeper. If they try after Day 4, the Forest wheel needs to land on Hippogriff to find her at all.
The payoff	Bramble home, safe in the paddock. In the finale she can swoop in and carry one student out of danger. The Thornbury will cry. So might you.

The Other Half

The Fenwick's quest. Leads to the most magical moment of the first half: the map waking up.

Given by	Cassius, Day 4 Lunch in the Courtyard. For the Fenwick.
Objectives	Find out who has the other half. Win it back. Join the halves.
Reward	50 XP and a rare Chocolate Frog card (which finishes Card Collector).

Three ways to pitch it

- Cassius waving it in the Courtyard: “Finders keepers.”
- His owl: “I know you have half of an old map, Fenwick. I have the other half. Courtyard, any lunchtime, if you’re brave.”
- The Fenwick’s half grows warm in their pocket whenever Cassius is near.

How it usually plays

Win it by trade, trick or duel. Cassius respects all three. When the halves join, give the Fenwick the other half with Give item: the whole castle shows when the map is open.

Clever solutions to allow

- Challenging him to a Dueling Club final for it (ties into Dueling Club Champion).
- Trading the rare card (but then Card Collector needs another).
- Stealing it while he is in the Hospital Wing on Day 3 night (DEX 15, sneaky, very satisfying).

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- He tore off a corner to keep for himself. The map works, but one room is missing.
- He wants to come with them. Let him. He is useful, and annoying.

If they ignore it	He sells it to an older student on Day 6. Getting it back is harder and costs more.
The payoff	The first time the Fenwick speaks the words and the whole castle appears on the TV with everyone’s footsteps: make the table go quiet for it. Turn the lights down.

The secret quests

These are found, not given. Reveal each one when the players stumble into it, and make the stumbling feel like their own cleverness.

The Old Cup

A secret that turns detention into treasure.

Found by	Detention in the Trophy Room (any Out after curfew that lands on Filch, or any rule-breaking he catches).
Objectives	Read the engraving on the old cup. Follow it to the Astronomy Tower. Find what was hidden there.
Reward	30 XP, the Moon ring clue and Felix Felicis.

Three ways to pitch it

- Polishing the oldest cup, they notice tiny letters: “Where the stars are closest, the second ring waits.”
- Filch, muttering: “That one’s haunted, that cup. Every year someone sees writing on it.”
- The cup is warm. Nothing else in the room is.

How it usually plays

Read the riddle, climb the Astronomy Tower, find the Star chart among the star charts. A great lead-in to the Serpent in the Stars puzzle.

Clever solutions to allow

- Players who get themselves detention on purpose to find it. Reward the scheming.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- Filch is watching them polish. Reading the cup without him noticing: DEX 12.

If they ignore it	It stays a cup.
The payoff	It turns a punishment into a discovery, and teaches the table that breaking rules in this castle can pay.

The Turning Lock

The ticking chest in the Room of Requirement. Inside: the Time-Turner.

Found by	Finding the Room of Requirement. From Day 5 an unknown hand sends directions by owl.
Objectives	Find the room. Find the three ring clues (Trophy Room, Astronomy Tower, Owlery). Turn the rings.
Reward	60 XP, and by hand: the Time-Turner (one use).

Three ways to pitch it

- A ticking sound in the room that gets louder as they approach.
- The ring clues they found on Day 1 suddenly make sense.
- The unknown hand's owl, which nobody can trace.

How it usually plays

If they found the ring clues early (Day 1), this can come together fast. The answer is Serpent, Moon, Owl.

Clever solutions to allow

- Working out the room exists from rumours before the owl arrives.

Complications, if it is going too smoothly

- The room gives them what they need, not what they want: the chest is in a different place every visit.

If they ignore it	The owl arrives on Day 5 anyway.
The payoff	The Time-Turner is the safety net for the whole campaign. Players who have it play braver.

The Painter's Bargain (Day 5 onwards) and The Trials Beneath (Day 7) are in the DM Guide. They belong to the second half of the week.